Green Paper 16 — Nervous-System Love

The body does not have to be calm to be heard

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Your body is the altar.
Your presence is the prayer.

The body is often welcomed only after it has made itself convenient.

When it can sit still, explain itself, wait its turn and speak without disturbing the room, it may be treated as reasonable. When it shakes, withdraws, flares, forgets, needs assistance or takes longer, its signals are more easily interpreted as noise.

Nervous-system love begins somewhere else. It begins with the recognition that the body retains its standing in every state. A person does not lose dignity when overwhelmed. Dysregulation does not remove voice, rights, consent or authority over one's own boundaries. Calm may support reflection, but calm is not an entrance requirement for being heard.

And the nervous system is not the whole body. It is one of the ways the body listens and responds. Embodied life also includes appetite, fatigue, pain, pleasure, movement, illness, touch, age, breath and the changing capacity to take part.

The body is not merely where the world leaves its marks. It is also where the world is met.

There is no standard body

Institutions often behave as though a neutral body exists: rested, mobile, articulate, available during office hours and able to sustain attention at the required pace. Other bodies then appear as deviations to be accommodated.

But no body is the standard setting of the human. Bodies become ill, recover, age, menstruate, carry pain, respond to medication, change shape, live with disability, lose sleep and move through periods of sharply different capacity. This is not an exception surrounding an otherwise stable human form. It is embodied life.

An arrangement that works only for the quick, rested and verbally confident body is therefore not neutral. It has been designed around a particular body while leaving its assumptions unnamed.

Gaia does not require performance.
She asks only that we come home to the body
as a place worthy of reverence.

Here, reverence begins by refusing to make usefulness the measure of belonging.

The body is not a private failure

A body is never only individual. It has been shaped in relationships, households, institutions, streets, workplaces, histories and ecologies. It responds not only to what is happening inside a person, but to what has repeatedly happened around them.

Noise, scarcity, humiliation, surveillance, displacement, unstable work and unsafe housing can all be carried bodily. So can affection, trustworthy routines, fair payment, breathable space, shared meals and the experience of being met without having to perform.

Bodily knowledge is real, situated and still capable of learning. Bodies remember, anticipate and protect. Sensation can be listened to alongside experience, material evidence and the knowledge carried by others. It belongs in the inquiry.

The question is not simply: *What is wrong with this person?*

It is also: *What is this body responding to? What has the surrounding field asked it to carry?*

Regulation is movement

Regulation is sometimes mistaken for calmness. But a living nervous system does not remain in one preferred state. It mobilises, protects, reaches, rests, alerts, withdraws and returns.

Regulation is not obedience dressed in therapeutic language. It is not the suppression of anger, urgency, grief or refusal so an existing arrangement can continue without friction. A person with greater capacity may become more able to say no, leave the room, name harm, ask for help or interrupt what others have normalised.

Nor is regulation a solitary achievement. We regulate with and through one another. A clear agreement can regulate. A door that can be closed can regulate. Enough time, useful information, food, shade and the presence of someone who does not rush an answer can regulate. So can knowing that a no will not be punished.

The relevant capacity is not permanent composure. It is flexibility: the possibility of moving through activation without being abandoned there, finding protection without being imprisoned by it, and returning to contact without being forced.

A body knows — and keeps learning

The body often registers something before words arrive: that the tempo is wrong, that a relationship has become unsafe, that a place allows breathing, or that a decision is not yet mature.

This knowledge can enter a shared inquiry. Sensation may become observation; observation may meet other experience, material evidence and changing conditions. What begins as tightening, fatigue, warmth or unease can gradually acquire language without being stripped of its bodily origin.

This is one opening into moral biology: an inquiry into how dignity, conscience, relation and living conditions are experienced through embodied life.

Institutions need ways for such knowledge to enter before it becomes absence, illness, conflict or collapse.

The wandering nerve and the connective tissue

The vagus nerve has been called the wandering nerve. It travels from the brainstem through the neck and into the chest and abdomen, participating in an ongoing conversation among voice, breath, heart, lungs, digestion and the brain. Much of its traffic is sensory and travels towards the brain: the body is continually reporting on the conditions of its own life.

For some, discovering this changes the image of the body. What appeared to be separate — breathing, heartbeat, digestion, attention, speech and social contact — can be understood as parts of a living exchange. Regulation is not produced by the brain and delivered to a passive body. It emerges through communication in both directions.

Fascia offers another image. Connective tissue surrounds, separates and links muscles, organs, nerves and vessels while allowing bodily structures to move in relation. It is living and richly innervated, involved in proprioception, load and pain. Tension is distributed. Movement in one place may be carried elsewhere. The body is connected before it is explained.

Neither vagus nor fascia explains the whole body. They make something of its relational intelligence tangible: signals travelling, tissues responding, tension distributed, movement carried from one place to another. The body is not a machine governed from above. It is a living conversation.

Knowing is not located only in conscious thought. Connection is not merely an idea. It has anatomy.

Rhythm and rest

Collective time is often organised as though every body should open at the same speed. Decisions are scheduled before trust exists. Recovery is allocated a deadline. Participation favours quick speech and stable attention.

But emergence has seasons.

Every being has a right to unfold in their own season.
Growth is not a race — it is a rhythm.

Respecting rhythm does not mean postponing every decision until everyone feels ready. Collective life contains deadlines, emergencies and incompatible needs. It means making time part of the decision: who must answer now, who has had time to understand, who may return later, and which forms of participation remain after the meeting ends.

Rest belongs to the same architecture. If it is a right rather than a reward, it must become visible in pacing, staffing, budgets, handovers, meeting length and recovery after intensity. An organisation cannot credibly speak of care while depending on repeated exceptional sacrifice.

Nothing in nature blooms all year.

Rest need not mean stillness. It may be sleep, walking, repetitive work, laughter, music, solitude or company without demand. The task is not to prescribe its correct form, but to protect the conditions in which a body can recognise what restores it.

The Earth touches us back

A body is bounded, but not sealed. Air enters the lungs. Water becomes tissue. Food, microbes, temperature, sound and touch continually cross the apparent divide between organism and environment.

The Earth touches us back, through sensation.

Embodiment therefore means more than looking inward. It also asks: What air is this body breathing? What water enters it? What work wears it down? Which relations and landscapes help it live? Which costs have been transferred into other bodies and places?

The body makes otherwise distant arrangements directly consequential. Pollution, extraction, care, architecture and public policy eventually become breath, sleep, movement, illness, nourishment or possibility. The body is where the abstract returns to life.

Nervous-system love receives the living body before demanding that it become understandable. It lets distress call for care, conflict disclose difference and bodily signals bring forward what a system might otherwise never know. It makes care material in the conditions through which bodies live.

The body does not have to be calm to be heard. It does not have to be useful to belong. And it does not have to become abstract before its knowledge can enter the common world.

The body is worthy of love before it becomes understandable.

Embodiment is not something you do.
It is something you trust.

Perhaps trust begins by refusing to abandon the body that carries the question.

Poetic source: Gaia Bloom Constitution (2025).

Stewarded by Lars A. Engberg.